



film review

All Star Simplicity

A small movie with a big heart and bigger message

TAARE ZAMEEN PAR

Director: Aamir Khan

Starring: Aamir Khan, Darsheel Safary, Tisca Chopra

Some movies tend to sweep you away with their razzle dazzle. Others manage to tiptoe their way into your heart, put their warm arms around you, and never let go. *Taare Zameen Par* is a tiptoe sort of movie, where the simplest things in life are allowed to breathe onscreen, whether it is a little boy fighting with water in his shower, another little boy sitting on his father's shoulders and devouring an ice-cream, and yet another's face collapsing in disappointment when he is unable to win a match his father wants him to.

Good things come in small packages, the best is saved for the last—both clichés are absolutely true for Aamir Khan's director-

SMALL WONDER: A still from the film (above); Safary

rial debut. *Taare Zameen Par* is quite simply the best film of the year. Its premise is as old as the hills—boy with disability conquers his fears and then the world (or at least his school). But the way writer Amole Gupte has captured it is quite unusual. Ishaan Awasthi is a nine-year-old boy who suffers from undetected dyslexia, which makes him a figure of fun in school—he can't write right, spell right, even behave right. He's pilloried by his teachers and misunderstood by his parents. Every time he's put in a spot, he runs away, slips into

naughtiness or just refuses to speak up. It's a complex performance, part baffled, part bindaas, which little Darsheel Safary pulls off quite smartly.

As director, Khan has got the tone of the movie just right. Every time you think it's in a danger of turning maudlin, he inserts a tiny little surprise. When Ishaan wins the painting competition, there is no slow motion race to grab the trophy, just a heart-breaking silent breakdown; when his parents learn how he's beaten the odds against him in the

PTA, there is no happy family song, just a simple goodbye to his teacher. Khan got the cameraman to shoot the film in available light, just as the eye sees. It helps. Every time Ishaan takes time off to step into a puddle even

when his mother is dragging him to the school bus, every time he stops to look at the birds when his teacher is in class, the film looks entirely natural.

It is also truly collaborative. The songs are little poems: *dekho dekho kya woh ped hai/chadar ode ya khada koi/baarish hai ya aasmaan ne chhod diye hai nal khule kahin* (is that a tree or someone shrouded in a blanket/is this rain or has the sky left its taps open?) The dialogues are laced with wit and wisdom—this must be the only mainstream movie which quotes from Oscar Wilde and the Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan. And the paintings—art turns out to be Ishaan's saviour—by Gupte and Samir Mandal, are little masterpieces.

Khan says he has always swum upstream, whether it is *Sarfarosh*, *Lagaan* or *Rang de Basanti*. He's pretty much right. One may not always agree with his movies, but they rarely leave one cold. This one, in particular, is haunting precisely in its everydayness—the self-flagellation from the mother, who says she gave up her career for Ishaan, the edgy competitiveness of the father, who thinks Ishaan's dyslexia is just an excuse to wriggle out of work, even the elder brother's almost robotic will to excel.

As an actor, Khan's perfectionism is now old news. He plays the life-changing art teacher, Nikhumb sir, with the right mix of cheekiness and preachiness. But it's as a director that he is a find—as big as his film's heart.

by Kaveree Bamzai

